

Cat Compulsive Self Grooming Fix — Action Checklist

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DIAGNOSTIC TESTING

- ☐ **Diagnostic Testing:** Request urinalysis with culture to rule out urinary tract infection or FLUTD, which commonly causes cats to groom the groin and hind legs obsessively.
- ☐ **Diagnostic Testing:** Ask your vet to run bloodwork with a specific thyroid panel (T4 test) since hyperthyroidism is common in cats over seven years old and causes increased grooming.
- ☐ **Diagnostic Testing:** Demand a full dermatologic workup including skin scrapings for mange, fungal culture for ringworm, and a structured flea trial rather than basic flea combing.
- ☐ **Diagnostic Testing:** Conduct an eight-to-twelve-week food elimination trial using only a novel or hydrolyzed protein diet with zero treats, table food, or flavored medications during the entire period.

VET COLLABORATION

- ☐ **Vet Collaboration:** Start your vet appointment by saying you want to rule out medical causes systematically before treating this as a behavioral problem, which signals you're a motivated participant.
- ☐ **Vet Collaboration:** Bring this checklist to your appointment to show your vet you've done research and you're ready to participate actively in your cat's diagnostic process.
- ☐ **Vet Collaboration:** Seek a second opinion or veterinary dermatologist if your current vet refuses to run these diagnostic tests, because partial workups often miss treatable medical causes.
- ☐ **Vet Collaboration:** Accept that if every medical test returns normal, you are dealing with true psychogenic alopecia and need to shift your treatment strategy accordingly.

TREATMENT STRATEGY

- ☐ **Treatment Strategy:** Explore non-steroidal medication options with your vet since corticosteroids have failed and the underlying cause requires a different pharmaceutical approach.
 - ☐ **Treatment Strategy:** Address the neurological habit component directly because even when medical causes are ruled out, the grooming pattern has become self-reinforcing and needs separate treatment.
 - ☐ **Treatment Strategy:** Use an E-collar or protective gear only as a temporary bridge while treating the root cause, since cones alone never resolve compulsive licking long-term.
 - ☐ **Treatment Strategy:** Implement long-term anxiety reduction strategies because the grooming habit has a stress-response component that must be managed for any treatment to hold.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.